

# Winners and Establishable Cards

As soon as dummy comes down, declarer asks: how many tricks do I have? Where can I find more?



## 1 Winner

A card that, **played now**, wins the trick. Also called a **sure trick**.



2 winners  
the ace and the king

## 2 Establishable card

A card that **will become** a winner after some work. Here the ace is missing: keep leading the suit until an opponent takes it.



0 winners  
3 establishable

## 3 Establishing by force

Lead the suit one card at a time until the opponents take their higher honors. **It is the only technique that always works**: one hundred percent of the time.

## 4 Equal cards

Touching cards have the same power: in **AKQJ** the jack wins just like the ace, 4 winners. It works **across both hands** too: with AQ2 in dummy, South's king is a winner.

N ♠ AQ2  
S ♠ K43

3 winners  
as long as two honors never fall on the same trick

## 5 The long side rules

Never more tricks than cards in the long hand.

## 6 How many can you establish?

Cards in the long hand, minus the missing honors.

|                                                   |                                                 |                                                   |                                                |                                                 |                                                    |                                                  |
|---------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------|
| N ♠ J109<br>S ♠ AKQ<br>3 on each side<br>3 tricks | N ♥ 109<br>S ♥ AKQJ2<br>South has 5<br>5 tricks | N ♦ AKJ942<br>S ♦ Q103<br>North has 6<br>6 tricks | N ♣ KQ92<br>S ♣ J103<br>A missing<br>4 - 1 = 3 | N ♣ KQ954<br>S ♣ J103<br>A missing<br>5 - 1 = 4 | N ♥ Q9854<br>S ♥ J1032<br>A K missing<br>5 - 2 = 3 | N ♠ KJ9863<br>S ♠ Q102<br>A missing<br>6 - 1 = 5 |
|---------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------|

## 7 Declarer's plan, after the opening lead

### 1 · Count your winners

Suit by suit, across both hands.

### 2 · Find what to establish

Start with the suit that can give **the most tricks**.

### 3 · Establish, then cash

Don't rush to play your winners: you need them later.

Careful: sometimes, once the suit is established, you must regain the lead before you can cash it.

## 8 Let's try: South declares, West leads

NORTH · DUMMY

♠ AQ8 ♥ 76 ♦ K65 ♣ K10932

SOUTH · DECLARER

♠ K62 ♥ A982 ♦ A43 ♣ QJ6

West leads the Q♦

| SUIT       | WINNERS | ESTABLISHABLE |                           |
|------------|---------|---------------|---------------------------|
| ♠ Spades   | 3       | —             | A K Q                     |
| ♥ Hearts   | 1       | —             | A                         |
| ♦ Diamonds | 2       | —             | A K                       |
| ♣ Clubs    | 0       | 4             | 5 - 1: the ace is missing |
| Total      | 6       | + 4           | = 10 tricks               |

South wins the lead → plays **clubs** at once until the ace is gone → wins any return and cashes out